Muss-Arnolt in Harper (ed.), Assyrian and Babylonian Literature (1901) – Tablet XI

<!-- UNCORRECTED archive.org OCR (djvu.txt of item 'cu31924083983944'), lines 21919-22771 of the OCR file, extracted 2026-10-16. Diacritics, line numbers and transliterations are frequently garbled: always check against the PDF page images. -->

TABLET XI

contains the famous account of the deluge. The text of this tablet is published by Friedrich Delitzsch in his " Assyrische Lesestiicke," third edition, pp. 101-109; and, more recently, by Professor Haupt in the second part of his " Das Babylonische Nimrodepos," pp. 133-150, this latter being a complete, critical text, giving all the variant readings and additional remarks beneath the text.* The original publication on plates 50 and 51 in the fourth volume oi the " Inscriptions of Western Asia " has been re-edited, with many improvements, in the second edition of this volume, by Theophilus G. Pinches, in 1891 (plates 43 and 44). — Translations of the deluge story (lines 1-104 of Haupt's edition), or of parts thereof, have been made, since the days of George Smith, by many Assyriolog^sts — e. g.. Fox Talbot, Jules Oppert, F. Lenormant. Special attention is called here to the following translations: i. Peter Jensen, in his " Cosmology of the Babylonians " (pp. 365-446), and in "Assyrisch-babylonische Mythen und Epen," pp. 228-257; 2. Alfred Jeremias, in his " Izdabar-Nimrod " (pp. 32-40, translating the whole eleventh tablet); 3. H. Winckler, " Keilinschriftliches Textbuch zum Alten Testament " (pp. 70-87) ; 4. Heinrich Zimmem in Gunkel's book on " Creation and Chaos " (pp. 423-428); 5. L. W. King, "First Steps in Assyrian" (London, 1898, pp. 161-181, text, transliteration, and translation), and the same author's " Babylonian Religion and Mythology " (London, 1899, chap, iv, pp. 121-146); 6. C. J. Ball, "Light from the East, or the Witness of the Monuments " (London, 1899, pp. 34 foil.); 7. According to Professor Jastrow's statement on p. 730 of his " Religion of Babylonia and As-

' The texts belonging to Tablet XI occupy pages 95-150 of the second part— viz., pp. 95-105 contain the fragments of copy A of this tablet 106-113 the fragments of copy B ; pp. 114-119 those of copy C ; an 120-132 a number of additional fragments.

Syria," the transliteration and translation of the deluge text, together with critical notes and commentary, by Professor Haupt in the forthcoming third edition of Schrader's " Die Keilinschriften und das Alte Testament," is to be by far the best ever published. — In general, see also the article " Deluge," by H. Zimmern and T. K. Cheyne in Cheyne and Black's " Encyclopaedia Biblica," London, 1899, vol. i, cols. 1 05 5- 1 066.

Tablet XI continues the dialogue between Per-napishtim and Gilgamesh, begun in Cols. V and VI of the preceding tablet.

Gilgamesh said to him, to Per-napishtim, the distant:*
" I gaze upon thee (in amazement), O Per-napishtim!
Thy appearance has not changed, like unto me thou art

also.
And thy nature itself has not changed, like unto me thou

art also,
though thou hast departed this life. But my heart has still

to struggle
against all that no longer (?) lies upon thee.
Tell me, How didst thou come to dwell (here?) and obtain

eternal life among the gods? "

[From the shore Per-napishtim, the favourite of the gods, now relates the story of the deluge to the hero, who, sitting in his ship, is listening to him.]

Per-napishtim then said unto Gilgamesh:

" I will reveal unto thee, O Gilgamesh, the mysterious

story,
and the mystery ^ of the gods I will tell thee.
The city of Shurippak,* a city which, as thou knowest,
is situated on the bank of the river Euphrates.
That city was corrupt, so that the gods within it
decided to bring about a deluge, even the great gods,
as many as?] there were: their father, Anu;

' Others, far removed ; the remote, perhaps with reference to line 2 (see below, p. 358, lines 17-20).
' Or, decision (?, Haupt).
' According to Jensen and others, the city of Larancha.

their counsellor, the warrior Bel;

their leader, Ninib;

their champion, the god En-nu-gi.

But Ea, the lord of unfathomable wisdom, argued with

them.
Their plan he told to a reed-hut, (saying):
' Reed-hut, reed-hut, clay-structure, day-structure!
Reed-hut, hear; clay-structure, pay attention!^
Thou man of Shurippak, son of Ubara-Tutu,*
Build a house, construct a ship;
Forsake thy possessions, take heed for thy life!
Abandon thy goods, save (thy) life,

and bring living seed of every kind into the ship.
As for the ship, which thou shalt build,
let its proportions be well measured:
Its breadth and its length shall bear proportion each to each,
and into the sea then launch it.'
I took heed, and said to Ea, my lord:
' I will do, my lord, as thou hast commanded;
I will observe and will fulfil the command.
But what shall I answer to (the inquiries of) the city, the
people, and the elders? '
Ea opened his mouth and spoke,
and he said unto me, his servant:
' Man, as an answer say thus unto them:
" I know that Bel hates me.
No longer can I live in your city;
Nor on Bel's territory can I live securely any longer; ^
I will go down to the ' deep,' I will live with Ea, my lord.
Upon you he * will (for a time?) pour down rich blessing.
He will grant you] fowl [in plenty] and fish in abundance,
Herds of cattle and an abundant] harvest.
Shamash has appointed a time when the rulers of darkness '
at eventide will pour down upon you] a destructive rain." '

> See note 2 on page 358. » Kidin-Marduk.

• Literally, lay down my head ; Bel's territory was the land, as the ocean was that of Ea. « Bel.

• So Zimmern, Jensen (1900) ; others, when he who sends heavy rains (Jeremias).

The lower part of Col. I is unfortunately much muti-
lated. Line 48 seems to read:

As soon as early dawn appeared.

Then continues line 55:

The brightness [of day?] I feared;

All that was necessary I collected together.

On the fifth day I drew its design; ^

In its middle part its sides were ten gar * high;

Ten gar also was the extent of its deck;

I added a front-roof to it and closed it in.

I built it in six stories,

thus making seven floors in all;

The interior of each I divided again into nine partitions.*

Beaks for water within I cut out.

I selected a pole and added all that was necessary.

Three (variant, five) shar of pitch I smeared on its outside;

three shar of asphalt I used for the inside (so as to make

it water-tight).
Three shar of oil the men carried, carrying it in vessels.
One shar of oil I kept out and used it for sacrifices,
while the other two shar the boatman stowed away.
For the temple of the gods (?) I slaughtered oxen;
I killed lambs (?) day by day.
Jugs of cider (?), of oil, and of sweet wine.
Large bowls (filled therewith?), like river water (i. e., freely)

I poured out as libations.
I made a feast (to the gods) like that of the New- Year's

Day.*

To god Shamash my hands brought oil."*
[* * *] ® the ship was completed.

' Or, I constructed its hull.

' = one hundred and twenty cubits.

' Thus making in all sixty-three partitions.

* This festival, celebrated on New- Year's day, was held later in commemoration of the deluge. New- Year's day being originally celebrated in memory of the creation.

' That is, I sacrificed to him.

' Zimmern, on the seventh day (but??).
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[* * *] heavy was the work, and

I added tackling above and below, [and after all was finished] ,

The ship sank into water] two thirds of its height.

With all that I possessed I filled it;

with all the silver I had I filled it;

with all the gold I had I filled it;

with living creatures of every kind I filled it.

Then I embarked also all my family and my relatives,

cattle of the field, beasts of the field, and the uprighteous people — all them I embarked.

A time had Shamash appointed, (namely):

' When the rulers of darkness send at eventide a destructive rain,

then enter into the ship and shut its door.' ^

This very sign came to pass, and

The rulers of darkness sent a destructive rain at eventide.

I saw the approach of the storm,

and I was afraid to witness the storm;

I entered the ship and shut the door.

I intrusted the guidance of the ship to Purur-bel, the boatman,^

the great house, and the contents thereof.

As soon as early dawn appeared,

there rose up from the horizon a black cloud,

within which the weatl;ier god (Adad) thundered,

and Nabu and the king of the gods (Marduk) went before.

The destroyers passed across mountain and dale (literally, country).

Dibbara, the great,^ tore loose the anchor-cable (?).

There went Ninib and he caused the banks to overflow;

the Anunnaki lifted on high (their) torches,

and with the brightness thereof they illuminated the universe.

The storm brought on by Adad swept even up to the heavens,

' Variant reading says, thy ship. • Or Uragal (?).

' Of course, not the same as Arad-Ea, mentioned before.

and all light was turned into darkness.

[ ] overflooded the land like * * *

It blew with violence and in one day (?) it rose above the mountains (??).

Like an onslaught in battle it rushed in on the people.

Not could brother look after brother.

Not were recognised the people from heaven.

The gods even were afraid of the storm;

they retreated and took refuge in the heaven of Anu.*

There the gods crouched down like dogs, on the inclosure of heaven "^ they sat cowering.

Then Ishtar cried out like a woman in travail,*

and the lady of the gods lamented with a loud voice,* (say-

ing):

' The world of old has been turned back into clay,

because I assented to this evil in the assembly of the gods.

Alas! that when I assented to this evil in the council of the gods,

I was for the destruction of my own people.

What I have created, where is it?

Like the spawn of fish it fills the sea.' ^

The gods wailed with her over the Anunnaki.

The gods were bowed down, and sat there weeping.

Their lips were pressed together (in fear and in terror).

Six days and nights

The wind blew, and storm and tempest, overwhelmed the country.

When the seventh day drew nigh the tempest, the storm, the battle

which they had waged like a great host began to moderate.

The sea quieted down; hurricane and storm ceased.

I looked out upon the sea and raised loud my voice,

But all mankind had turned back into clay.

' Jensen, the sky ; others, the highest part of heaven.

' The firmament ? ' Variant reading has, full of wrath.

' Jeremias, who always speaks kindly.

'• Zimmern translates lines 123 and 124, shall I ever again bring hu
beings into this world, when now, like the spawn of fish, they fill
sea?

Like the surrounding field had become the bed of the

rivers.*
I opened the air-hole and light fell upon my cheek.
Dumfounded I sank backward, and sat weeping,
while over my cheek flowed the tears.
I looked in every direction, and behold, all was sea.
Now, after twelve (days?) there rose (out of the water) a

strip of land.*
To Mount Nisir the ship drifted.
On Mount Nisir the boat stuck fast and it did not slip

away.
The first day, the second day. Mount Nisir held the ship

fast, and did not let it slip away.
The third day, the fourth day, Mount Nisir held the ship

fast, and did not let it slip away.
The fifth day, the sixth day. Mount Nisir held the ship

fast, and did not let it slip away.
When the seventh day drew nigh
I sent out a dove, and let her go.
The dove flew hither and thither,

but as there was no resting-place for her, she returned.
Then I sent out a swallow, and let her go.
The swallow flew hither and thither,

but as there was no resting-place for her she also returned.
Then I sent out a raven, and let her go.
The raven flew away and saw the abatement of the waters.
She settled down to feed,* went away, and returned no

more.
Then I let everything go out unto the four winds, and I

offered a sacrifice.
I poured out a libation upon the peak of the mountain.
I placed the censers seven and seven,

' That is, there was everything covered with water ; Jastrow, in plac
of dams, everything had become a marsh ; King, in place of fields,
before me a swamp ; Jensen (tgoo), as soon as daylight appeared, I

' Others, after twelve double hours ; Jeremias, twelve cubits high la
arose ; Zimraern, toward the twelfth (cardinal point) land arose.

"Either on floating carcasses or on the slimy mud; King, and she
came near, wading and croaking, but did not return.

and poured into them calamus, cedar-wood, and sweet-
incense.

The gods smelt the savour;

yea, the gods smelt the sweet savour;

the gods gathered like flies around the sacrificer.

But when now the lady of the gods (Ishtar) drew nigh,

she lifted up the precious ornaments (?) * which Anu had made according to her wish (and said):

' Ye gods here! by my necklace, not will I forget.

These days will I remember, never will I forget (them).

Let the gods come to the offering;

But Bel shall not come to the offering.

Since rashly he caused the flood-storm,

and handed over my people unto destruction.'

Now, when Bel drew nigh,

and saw the ship, the god was wroth,

and anger against the gods, the Igigi, filled his heart, (and he said):

'Who then has escaped here (with his life)?

No man was to survive the universal destruction.'

Then Ninib opened his mouth and spoke,

saying unto Bel, the warrior:

' Who but Ea could have planned this!

For does not Ea know all arts? '

Then Ea opened his mouth and spoke,

saying unto Bel, the warrior:

' Ay, thou wise one among the gods, thou warrior,

how rash of thee to bring about a flood-storm!

On the sinner visit his sin,

and on the wicked his wickedness;

but be merciful, forbear, let not all be destroyed! Be considerate, let not everything be [confounded] !

Instead of sending a flood-storm,

let lions ^ come and diminish mankind;

Instead of sending a flood-storm,

let tigers come and diminish mankind;

' Literally, the great lightnings.

• Compare 2 Kings, xvii, 25 ; Ezek., xiv, 15.

Instead of sending a flood-storm,

let famine come and smite the land;

Instead of sending a flood-storm,

let pestilence come and kill off the people.^

I did not reveal the mystery of the great gods.

(Some one?) caused Atrachasis to see (it) in a dream, and so

he (Per-napishtim) heard the mystery of the gods." *
Thereupon Bel arrived at a decision.
Bel went up into the ship,

took me by the hand and led me out.
He led out also my' wife and made her kneel beside me;
He turned us face to face, and standing between us, blessed

us, (saying):
' Ere this Per-napishtim was only human;
But now Per-napishtim and his wife shall be lofty like unto

the gods;
Let Per-napishtim live far away (from men) at the mouth of

the (two?) rivers.'
Then they took me and let us dwell far away at the mouth

of the rivers." '

After Per-napishtim had finished this account, he turned
to Gilgamesh and said:

" Now as for thee, which one of the gods shall give thee

strength,
that the life thou desirest thou shalt obtain?

■ See Ezek., xiv, 21 ; Jer., xv, 3.

' According to Dr. Jeremias, Atrachasis was not another name for Per-napishtim, but the name of a messenger of the gods ; his name = very wise ; Haupt, the most holy, religious. Through Atrachasis, Per-napishtim heard of the impending disaster. Professor Jastrow, in the New York " Independent," February 10 and 17, 1898, maintained that (i Per-napishtim was the hero of a local tradition of a rainstorm, subme ing a single city ; while (2) Atrachasis = Chasis-adra (cf. Gen. vi, prototype of SlffovOpos, was the hero of the larger Nature myth, base the annual phenomenon of the overflow of the Euphrates. See also Jas-trow, in " Zeitschrift f<Jr Assyriologie," vol. xii, pp. 288-301. Accor to most scholars, Ea addresses the hut in which Per-napishtim (= Atra sis) was sleeping, thus revealing to him in sleep the mystery of the

' For other accounts of the story of the deluge, see below, at the

of the twelfth tablet of the Nimrod epic.

THE GILGAMESH NARRATIVE

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Now sleep! " And for six days and seven nights

Gilgamesh resembled one lying lame.

Sleep came over him like a storm wind.

Then Per-napishtim said to his wife:

" Behold, here is the hero whose desire is life (= recovery)!

Sleep came upon him like a storm wind."

And the wife replied to Per-napishtim, the distant:

" Transform him; let the man eat of the charm-root.

Let him, restored in health, return on the road on which he came.

Let him pass out through the great door unto his own country."

And Per-napishtim said to his wife:

" The suffering (and torture) of the man pain thee.

Well, then, cook now for him the food and place it at his head."

And while Gilgamesh slept on board of his ship,

she cooked the food to place it at his head.

And while he slept on board of his ship,

firstly, his food was prepared (?);

secondly, it was peeled; thirdly, it was moistened;

fourthly, his food (?) was cleaned;

fifthly, shiba (i. e., old age) ^ was added;

sixthly, it was cooked;

seventhly, of a sudden the man was transformed, having eaten of the magic food.

Then spoke Gilgamesh, and said unto Per-napishtim, the distant:

" I had sunk down, and sleep had befallen me.

Of a sudden thou didst charm me, and thus help, me " (?).

And Per-napishtim said unto Gilgamesh:

" * * * Gilgamesh partake of (?) thy food.

* * * shall be told unto thee:

firstly, thy food was prepared (?);

secondly, it was peeled; thirdly, it was moistened;

fourthly, thy food (?) was cleaned;

• Name given to some plant of magic power (?),

fifthly, shipa was added;

sixthly, it was cooked;

seventhly, I transformed thee suddenly,

and thou didst eat of the magic food."

And Gilgamesh said unto Per-napishtim, the distant:

" What?] shall I do, Per-napishtim? whither shall I go?

The demon (of the dead?) has seized my [friend?].

Upon my couch death now sits.

And where my * * * there is death."

And Per-napishtim said to Arad-Ea, the ferryman:

" Arad-Ea, thou * * * at thy side (?), let the boat carry thee;

whosoever attempts to board [the ship?] exclude him from it.

The man, before whom thou goest,

has his body covered with sores,

and the eruption of his skin has altered the beauty of his body.

Take him, Arad-Ea, and bring him to the place of purification,

where he can wash his sores in water that they may become white as snow;

Let him cast off his (sore?) skin and the sea will carry it away;

His body shall then appear well (and healthy) ;

Let the turban also be replaced on his head,

and the garment that covers his nakedness.

Until he returns to his city,

until he arrives at his road.

The garment shall not shed [hair?], it shall remain entirely new."

And Arad-Ea took him and brought him to the place of purification,

where he washed his sores in water so that they became white as snow;

he cast off his (sore?) skin and the sea carried it away;

his body appeared well (and healthy) again;

He replaced also the turban on his head;

and the garment that covered his nakedness;

until he should return to his city;

until he should arrive at his road;

[the garment did not shed hair] , it remained entirely new.

Then Gilgamesh and Arad-Ea embarked again,

and during their journey the ship tossed to and fro.

[After Gilgamesh and Arad-Ea had returned from the
place of purification:]

The wife of Per-napishtim spoke unto her husband, the

distant, (saying):
" Gilgamesh did go away, laboured, and has pulled (the

oar?).
What now wilt thou do (or give), that he may return to

his country? "
And Gilgamesh lifted up the pole,
and drew the boat nearer to the shore.
Then Per-napishtim spoke unto Gilgamesh (and said):
" Gilgamesh, thou didst go away, didst labour and pull

(the oar?).
What now shall I give thee, that thou mayest return to

thy country?
I will reveal unto thee, Gilgamesh, a mystery,
and [the decision of the gods] I will announce unto thee.
There is a plant resembling buckthorn,
its thorn (?) stings like that of a bramble.
When thy hands can reach that plant * * * " ^
When Gilgamesh had heard this
he opened the * * *
bound heavy stones [to his feet],
which dragged him down to the sea [and thus he found the

plant] .
Then he grasped the (magic) plant.
He removed [from his feet] the heavy stones [and one

fell down?],

and a second he threw down to the [first?].
And Gilgamesh said unto Arad-Ea, the ferryman:

' The following lines 286-293 are greatly mutilated

" Arad-Ea, this plant is a plant of great renown (or transformation?);

and what man desires in his heart, he obtains.

I will take it to Erech the strong-walled, I will nurse (plant?) it there and then cut it off.

Its name is (?): ' Even an old man will be rejuvenated! *

I will eat of this and return (again) to the vigour of my youth."

[And now they start out to return home to Erech the strong-walled.]

Every twenty double-leagues they then took a meal:

and every thirty double-leagues they took a rest.

And Gilgamesh saw a well wherein was cool (and refreshing) water;

He stepped into it and poured out some water.

A^(demon in the shape of a) serpent darted out; the plant slipped {away from his hands] ;

he came [out of the well?], and took the plant away,

and as he turned back, he uttered a curse (?).

And after this Gilgamesh sat down and wept. ■

Tears flowed down his cheeks,

and he said unto Arad-Ea, the ferryman:

" Why, Arad-Ea, did my hands tremble?

Why did the blood of my heart stand still? ^

Not on myself did I bestow any benefit.

On the ground-lion (?) this benefit has been bestowed.

After a journey of only twenty double-leagues the plant has been snatched away.

As I opened the well, and lowered the vessel (?).

I see the sign, that has become an omen to me. I am to return,

leaving the ship on the shore."

Then they continued to take a meal every twenty double-leagues,

and every thirty double-leagfues they took a rest,

until they arrived at Erech the strong-walled.

' That is, why was I thus frightened ?

Gilgamesh then spoke to Arad-Ea, the ferryman, (and

said) :

" Arad-Ea, ascend and walk about on the wall of Erech,

Inspect the corner-stone, and examine its brick-work,

whether its wall is not made of burned brick,
and its foundation (overlaid with?) pitch. ' Sevenfold is

thy name ' (?).*

[The closing lines can not be correctly translated.]

Then follows the first line of Tablet XII; and the usual colophon indicating that the tablet is the eleventh of the Gilgamesh epic, copied faithfully from the original, and the property of Ashurbanipal.